

Primary Source Reading 1: The Good Will and the Meaning of Duty

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Immanuel Kant, Groundwork of the Metaphysic of Morals, translated by Thomas Kingsmill Abbott (1873)
Read before Lesson 14a: Why Reason, Not Feeling, Is the Basis of Morality

Before you read: Kant opens with one of the most famous sentences in philosophy, then spends several pages testing it against ordinary cases: a shopkeeper who is honest, a person who wants to live, a person who enjoys helping others. As you read, notice that in each case Kant is not asking whether the action is good — he assumes it is. He is asking something narrower and stranger: whether the *motive* behind it gives the action moral worth.

Only a Good Will Is Good Without Qualification

Nothing can possibly be conceived in the world, or even out of it, which can be called good, without qualification, except a good will. Intelligence, wit, judgement, and the other talents of the mind, however they may be named, or courage, resolution, perseverance, as qualities of temperament, are undoubtedly good and desirable in many respects; but these gifts of nature may also become extremely bad and mischievous if the will which is to make use of them... is not good. It is the same with the gifts of fortune. Power, riches, honour, even health, and the general well-being and contentment with one's condition which is called happiness, inspire pride, and often presumption, if there is not a good will to correct the influence of these on the mind.

A good will is good not because of what it performs or effects, not by its aptness for the attainment of some proposed end, but simply by virtue of the volition; that is, it is good in itself... Even if it should happen that, owing to special disfavour of fortune, or the niggardly provision of a step-motherly nature, this will should wholly lack power to accomplish its purpose, if with its greatest efforts it should yet achieve nothing, and there should remain only the good will, then, like a jewel, it would still shine by its own light, as a thing which has its whole value in itself.

The Honest Shopkeeper

It is always a matter of duty that a dealer should not overcharge an inexperienced purchaser; and wherever there is much commerce the prudent tradesman does not overcharge, but keeps a fixed price for everyone, so that a child buys of him as well as any other. Men are thus honestly served; but this is not enough to make us believe that the tradesman has so acted from duty and from principles of honesty: his own advantage required it... Accordingly the action was done neither from duty nor from direct inclination, but merely with a selfish view.

The Sympathetic Philanthropist

To be beneficent when we can is a duty; and besides this, there are many minds so sympathetically constituted that, without any other motive of vanity or self-interest, they find a pleasure in spreading joy around them... But I maintain that in such a case an action of this kind, however proper, however amiable it may be, has nevertheless no true moral worth, but is on a level with other inclinations... For the maxim lacks the moral import, namely, that such actions be done from duty, not from inclination.

Put the case that the mind of that philanthropist were clouded by sorrow of his own, extinguishing all sympathy with the lot of others, and that, while he still has the power to benefit others in distress, he is not touched by their trouble because he is absorbed with his own; and now suppose that he tears himself out of this dead insensibility, and performs the action without any inclination to it, but simply from duty, then first has his action its genuine moral worth.

Hypothetical and Categorical

Now all imperatives command either hypothetically or categorically. The former represent the practical necessity of a possible action as means to something else that is willed. The categorical imperative would be that which represented an action as necessary of itself without reference to another end, i.e., as objectively necessary.

If the action is good only as a means to something else, then the imperative is hypothetical; if it is conceived as good in itself and consequently as being necessarily the principle of a will which of itself conforms to reason, then it is categorical.

After you read: Notice that in every example, Kant agrees the outward action is right — the shopkeeper is honest, the philanthropist helps people, the person preserves their life. What he is isolating is something else entirely: whether the action flows from duty or merely happens to align with it. As you move into the lesson, ask yourself whether this distinction feels right to you, or whether it makes morality sound colder than it should.